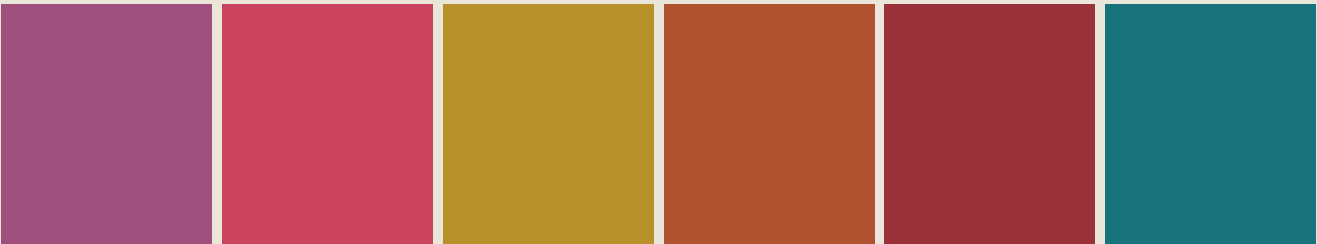


Marketing Strategy & Launch Plan



July – December 2026 · Launch: October 1
Prepared for Camila & Dana

Coffee matched to your flavor.

01 Executive Summary

Axis & Bloom launches October 1, 2026 with an unusual advantage: the product itself is the best marketing asset. A functional, delightful taste quiz means the brand can let people **experience** the promise months before they can buy. This plan is built around that fact.

The strategy in one paragraph: between now and October 1, every marketing dollar and hour goes toward one number — **qualified email subscribers who have taken the quiz**. Instagram, paid ads, and word of mouth all exist to feed the quiz; the quiz feeds the email list; the email list is who we launch to. From October through December, we convert that list into first customers and lean into the holiday season with a gifting product almost no coffee brand can copy: a personalized match, given as a gift.

Customer research (35 respondents, directional but consistent) sharpened the message. The audience — “The Reassured Regular,” an urban, mid-30s-to-40s, work-from-home parent — doesn’t want adventure. They want certainty. 94% prefer one confident pick over a large catalog; their #1 fear is wasting money on coffee they won’t enjoy; the #1 thing that earns their trust is a clear explanation of *why* this coffee was matched to them. So Axis & Bloom sells calm confidence, always explains the why, and replaces discounts with risk-reversal (a match promise).

The plan at a glance

JULY — Foundation: quiz becomes the lead magnet, email capture live, welcome emails written, pricing decided.

AUGUST — Build: archetype content engine on Instagram, first paid tests, list growing steadily.

SEPTEMBER — Momentum: waitlist push, early-access offer, referral mechanic, press & gifting outreach.

OCTOBER 1 — Launch to the list first, then widen.

NOVEMBER–DECEMBER — “Gift the Quiz” + Duo subscription carry the holiday season.

Success by December 31 looks like: 1,200–2,000 quiz-qualified email subscribers by launch day, 6–10% of the list purchasing in launch week, a repeatable content system that doesn’t exhaust a two-person team, and a holiday gifting product that becomes the brand’s signature growth loop.

02 Where You Are Now

An honest snapshot, because a plan is only useful if it starts from reality.

Assets in place

- **A working quiz.** Dana's Taste Finder is functional. This is rare — most pre-launch brands have only a "coming soon" page. You have an experience.
- **A finished visual identity.** Flavor-wheel mark, six archetype colors, packaging system, background patterns. Distinctive and Instagram-ready.
- **A clear brand idea.** Precision meets bloom; intelligence meets intimacy. The positioning writes itself from here.
- **World-class creative skill in-house.** Camila's filmmaking and art direction is the moat. Content that would cost other brands \$10k+ per shoot is an internal capability.
- **Infrastructure started.** Site live, Mailchimp connected, Instagram account posting.

Gaps to close (all covered in this plan)

- **Pricing undecided.** Blocks email copy, the launch offer, and the gift product. Decide by August 8 (see Section 05).
- **Site says September 1.** Change to October 1 before any traffic is sent.
- **Quiz results not yet gated by email** (or not systematically feeding Mailchimp with archetype data).
- **No measurement.** No analytics or ad pixel installed yet, so nothing can be learned from early traffic.
- **Audience of zero.** Not a problem — everyone starts here — but it means July/August numbers should be judged on trend, not size.

03 Positioning & Messaging

Positioning statement (internal compass, not public copy)

For people who love coffee but hate guessing, Axis & Bloom is the coffee brand that matches you to your flavor — and always explains why. Unlike specialty coffee shops that hand you forty bags and a vocabulary test, Axis & Bloom starts with you: a short quiz, one confident match, and a cup that simply feels right.

What we sell: certainty, not variety

This is the single most important strategic choice, and the research is unambiguous: 94% of surveyed customers want “1–2 options with high confidence” over a wide catalog. Every piece of copy that celebrates endless choice speaks to a 6% minority. The catalog is the back room; the match is the storefront.

Four messaging pillars

Every post, email, and ad should ladder up to one of these. If it doesn't, don't publish it.

Pillar	The message	Where it comes from
1. End the guessing	“You can't taste coffee before you buy it — so we ask first.” The quiz removes the risk and the overwhelm.	The #1 unprompted complaint: choice overload + can't taste before buying (~1 in 3 respondents).
2. Always the why	“Here's your match — and here's exactly why it fits you.” Never a black box.	The #1 trust driver (60%). Also differentiates from every ‘AI recommends’ gimmick.
3. Ritual & calm	Coffee as the quiet moment that makes the day work. Comfortable, present, settled — never hype.	Customers' own words: “heaven,” “home,” “a warm hug,” “a moment of Zen.”
4. Made for you	Six archetypes, a Bloom Dial, your name on the box. Coffee selected for you, not marketed at you.	The brand's core mechanic + the personalization promise of the unboxing.

Voice

Calm, warm, precise, quietly confident. The brand speaks like someone who knows exactly what they're doing and doesn't need to shout about it. Short sentences. Sensory words. No exclamation points in headlines. AI is mentioned as craft (“our taste-mapping”), never as spectacle (“powered by AI!”) — this audience trusts explanations, not technology claims.

Copy bank (use these, they're already tested)

- “Coffee matched to your flavor.” — the tagline; it stays.
- “You already know what you love. We help you name it.”
- “No more guessing in front of forty bags.”
- “You can't taste it before you buy it. So we ask first.”

- “When coffee is right, it feels like home.” / “...a warm hug.” / “...a moment of Zen.” (borrowed directly from survey answers)
- “Your axis is your flavor direction. Your bloom is how far you want to go.”

What NOT to say

- No “explore hundreds of coffees” — variety framing kills the promise.
- No hype or urgency-shouting (“INSANE deal!!”) — this audience finds it off-brand and it undercuts calm confidence.
- No jargon-first descriptions (washed process, 1,900 masl, cupping score) in top-of-funnel copy — 43% of the audience can’t articulate flavor language and the quiz exists precisely so they never have to.

04 Audience

Primary: The Reassured Regular

Mid-30s to mid-40s · urban · works from home or hybrid · often a parent of young kids · self-rates as moderately knowledgeable about coffee. Coffee is a load-bearing routine, not a hobby. They can feel when a coffee is wrong, but nearly half can't say why.

What they want	What they fear	What earns trust
One coffee they can rely on, chosen with confidence (94%). A morning that doesn't require decisions.	Wasting money on coffee they won't enjoy (49%) — a financial and emotional waste, not fear of change itself.	A clear explanation of why they were matched (60%), and a recommendation from someone whose taste they trust (51%).

Implication for every channel: lead with the pain (guessing), deliver the mechanism (quiz), prove it with the why (explanation), and remove the risk (match promise). That sequence — pain, mechanism, proof, safety — is the ad, the landing page, and the welcome email.

Secondary: The Coffee Explorer

Roughly 1 in 6 — higher sophistication, enjoys research and variety. Real, but not who the funnel is designed for. Serve them later with the Experimental archetype, rotating rare lots, and deeper educational content. Never redesign the first-touch experience around their appetite for variety.

A note on honesty about the data

The survey is 35 people, mostly from your own network. Treat it as strong directional validation, not market sizing. The quiz itself becomes the real research engine the moment it's live: every completion tells you which archetypes dominate, where people drop off, and what converts. Revisit these assumptions in September with real quiz data.

05 Offer & Pricing Framework

Pricing is still open, so this section gives you the framework and typical market reference points to decide quickly — target decision date **August 8**, because email copy, ads, and the gift product all depend on it. (Reference points only, not financial advice; validate against your actual costs and margins.)

The product ladder

Offer	What it is	Role in the business
Single bag	One matched 10–12 oz bag. Typical US specialty DTC range: \$18–\$24 + shipping.	The low-commitment first step. Answers the money-waste fear.
Discovery / trial size	Small-format first match (e.g., 4 oz taster or sample duo) at an accessible price.	Strongly recommended. Directly answers “can’t taste before buying” — likely to out-convert any discount.
Subscription	Matched coffee on a cadence (2/4/6 weeks), 5–15% below single-bag price, pause/skip anytime.	The core engine. Recurring revenue; where personalization compounds (Bloom Dial adjustments over time).
Duo / Household subscription	Two profiles, one box, one shipment. Each person gets their own match.	Your signature differentiator. Novel, giftable, and doubles basket size. Launch by November.
Gift the Quiz	Gift card or boxed gift: recipient takes the quiz, coffee arrives matched to them.	The Q4 hero. Solves the giver’s real problem (“I don’t know their taste”).

Risk reversal instead of discounts

Introduce **The Right Match Promise**: if your first match isn’t right, tell us what felt off and the next bag is on us — and your profile gets smarter. This does three jobs at once: neutralizes the 49% money-waste fear, generates precious taste feedback for the algorithm, and protects the brand from launching as a discount brand. A brand that discounts at birth teaches customers to wait for sales; a brand that guarantees the match teaches customers to trust it.

Free shipping threshold

Set free shipping just above the two-bag price point (e.g., free over \$40–\$45). It nudges the second bag — often the partner’s match, which quietly seeds the Duo subscription.

06 The 13-Week Pre-Launch Plan

Three phases, each with one job. Weekly detail follows; treat it as a rhythm, not a straitjacket. The one non-negotiable: **the quiz-to-email pipeline goes live in July**. Every week it isn't live is a week of audience you never capture.

Phase 1 — Foundation (July 6 – August 2): make the machine work

Week	Focus	Key actions
Jul 6–12	Fix the funnel	Change site date to October 1. Gate quiz results behind email ("Enter your email to see your archetype"). Tag each Mailchimp contact with their archetype. Install GA4 + Meta Pixel.
Jul 13–19	Welcome emails	Write and switch on the 5-email welcome sequence (Section 07). Email #1 delivers the archetype + the why — instantly.
Jul 20–26	Content system	Plan the archetype content series (one archetype world every ~2 weeks). Shoot the first batch of stills/Reels. Set the posting cadence: 3–4×/week.
Jul 27–Aug 2	Money decisions	Pricing workshop (Section 05 framework). Decide: bag price, trial size, subscription price/cadence, Right Match Promise wording, free-shipping threshold.

Phase 2 — Build (August 3 – 30): grow the list

Week	Focus	Key actions
Aug 3–9	Paid test begins	Launch first Meta (Instagram/Facebook) ads: \$20–40/day sending people to the quiz. Two angles: choice-overload pain vs. "find your archetype" curiosity. Let them fight.
Aug 10–16	Founder story	Publish the founders content: filmmaker + technologist build a calmer way to choose coffee. This is your trust layer — 51% trust taste recommendations from people, not brands.
Aug 17–23	Double down	Review ad results. Kill the losing angle, raise budget on the winner (up to ~\$50/day if cost per subscriber is under ~\$3). Second archetype world goes live.
Aug 24–30	Photography bank	Big shoot: build a 6–8 week library of archetype still-lives, hands, ritual moments, packaging. Future-you will be grateful in the launch chaos.

Phase 3 — Momentum (August 31 – September 27): turn the list into a launch

Week	Focus	Key actions
Aug 31–Sep 6	Early-access offer	Announce to the list: subscribers get first access October 1 + a founding perk (free shipping on first order or an archetype card set — not a discount). "Share your match" referral goes live.

Week	Focus	Key actions
Sep 7–13	Press & seeding	Send 20–30 beautiful PR boxes: design press, food/coffee newsletters, and ~10 micro-influencers (5k–50k followers) whose aesthetic matches. Let them take the quiz first — the unboxing IS the story.
Sep 14–20	Ops dry run	Full test: order placed → box packed → card printed → shipped → unboxed on camera. Fix everything that squeaks. Raise ad spend toward \$50–75/day.
Sep 21–27	Final countdown	Archetype reveal series peaks on IG. Email: “One week. Your match is waiting.” Confirm inventory across all six archetypes against list size.

Launch week (September 28 – October 4)

Day	Action
Mon Sep 28	Email + IG: “3 days.” Behind-the-scenes film of boxes being prepared.
Wed Sep 30	Email to list: doors open tomorrow 9am, your early access link. IG Stories countdown.
Thu Oct 1	LAUNCH — email at 9am to the list with early access + founding perk (48h window). IG launch film. Founders go personal on Stories all day.
Fri Oct 2	Second email to non-openers (same content, new subject line — standard practice, roughly +20–30% more reach).
Sat–Sun Oct 3–4	Share first customer moments. Sunday: “founding perk ends tonight” email. Then breathe.

07 Channel Playbooks

Instagram — the theater

Role: where the brand is felt. Instagram's job is not followers; it's making strangers want to take the quiz. Every profile visit should meet a pinned "Find your flavor" link.

Three content pillars (map 1:1 to messaging pillars, rotating 3–4 posts/week):

- **Archetype worlds (the film).** Cinematic 20–40s Reels + still-life carousels, one archetype every two weeks. Chocolate & Nutty lives in wood, ceramic, morning shadow; Fruity in glass, berries, movement. This is where Camila's craft becomes unfair advantage.
- **The quiet why (the trust).** Plain-language posts on how matching works, what the Bloom Dial is, why we ask about mood instead of tasting notes. Carousel format. Calm, confident, zero jargon.
- **Ritual & people (the feeling).** Hands, kitchens, first-sip moments, founder Stories. The "heaven / home / warm hug" register. This pillar is allowed to be imperfect and human.

Cadence: 3 feed posts + 2–3 Stories days per week. Reels carry reach; carousels carry saves; Stories carry relationship. **Growth reality check:** from zero, organic follower growth will be slow — that's normal. Paid distribution (below) does the reaching; Instagram's organic job is to convert attention into quiz-takers and to look undeniable when press and gift recipients check the profile.

Email — the engine

Role: where the money is. Email is the only channel you own. List quality beats list size: everyone on it has taken the quiz, so you know their archetype — segment everything by it.

Welcome sequence (automated in Mailchimp, triggered by quiz completion):

#	Timing	Email	Job
1	Instantly	"You're [Archetype]. Here's why."	Deliver the result + the explanation (the 60% trust driver). Tease what arrives Oct 1.
2	Day 2	"How we matched you"	Plain-language walk-through of the taste-mapping. Demystify the AI. This email exists because explanation = trust.
3	Day 5	"Inside the world of [Archetype]"	Sensory storytelling for their archetype. Beautiful, save-worthy, forwards well.
4	Day 9	"Why we built this" — Dana & Camila	Founder story. A filmmaker and a technologist, tired of guessing. Human, short, photo-led.
5	Day 14	"October 1: your match arrives"	Early access explained + the founding perk + one ask: "Know someone who'd love their own match? Send them the quiz."

Benchmarks to expect (so you know what "good" is): welcome emails typically see 50–70% opens; ongoing sends 35–45% opens and 1–3% clicks for a small warm list. Below that, fix subject lines first, segmentation second.

Website & quiz — the converter

- One job above the fold: start the quiz. Everything else (About, archetypes, How it works) supports that.
- Results page order: archetype name → the why (2–3 sentences) → “your coffees arrive October 1” → email capture (pre-launch) / matched products (post-launch).
- Add the Right Match Promise near every buy button from day one.
- Watch two numbers: quiz completion rate (target 60%+) and results-to-email rate (target 70%+ while gated).

Paid ads — the amplifier

Crawl-walk-run. **Crawl (Aug):** \$20–40/day on Meta, objective = quiz starts, two message angles, creative pulled from your best organic posts. **Walk (Sep):** \$50–75/day on winners; add a retargeting ad (people who visited but didn’t finish the quiz). **Run (Oct–Dec):** scale what pays. The number that matters pre-launch: **cost per quiz-completed subscriber — healthy is roughly \$2–4**. After launch it becomes cost per first order (see Section 09).

Word of mouth & referral — the multiplier

51% trust a recommendation from someone whose taste they trust — nearly as powerful as your own explanation, and free. Two mechanics: **Share your match** (every quiz result gets a beautiful, archetype-colored shareable card + link) and, post-launch, **Give a match, get a perk** (refer a friend, both get free shipping or a taster). Archetype results are identity content — people share what describes them. Make sharing gorgeous and one-tap.

08 Q4: The Holiday Season Plan

“Q4” = the fourth quarter of the year (October–December). In US retail it is the biggest buying season by far — Black Friday (Nov 27), Cyber Monday (Nov 30), and December gifting. Launching October 1 means your first twelve weeks ride this wave, and Axis & Bloom is unusually well built for it: **most coffee gifts are a guess; yours is a match.**

The Q4 calendar

Window	Focus	What happens
Oct 1–31	Launch & stabilize	Convert the list, fix operational squeaks, collect the first 20–30 reviews and unboxing photos (ask every customer by email at day 10 — reviews are your Q4 ammunition).
Nov 1	Gift the Quiz launches	Gift card + physical gift box go live. Duo/Household subscription launches alongside — “two profiles, one box” is a natural gift.
Nov 20–30	Black Friday / Cyber Monday	Gift-led, not discount-led (see below). Email is the workhorse: 4–5 sends across the window is normal and expected by shoppers.
Dec 1–18	Gifting peak	Weekly gift-focused emails + heavy IG on unboxing beauty. Dec 15–18: last-call for shipped gifts (confirm exact carrier cutoffs in early Dec).
Dec 19–24	Digital saves the day	“Too late to ship, right on time to match” — digital Gift-the-Quiz cards sellable until Dec 24, delivered by email instantly. A revenue window most brands waste.
Dec 26–31	The second gift wave	Gift recipients arrive to redeem. Their first experience IS the quiz — greet them beautifully. Also: “treat yourself” messaging works after Christmas.

The BFCM stance: gift-led, not discount-led

Deep discounting in your first sixty days would teach customers the price isn’t real and attract deal-hunters who never return. Instead: **bundle value** (gift box includes the archetype card set / a brewing insert), **founding-member framing** on the Duo subscription (“lock the founding price”), and at most a modest, dignified offer (e.g., free shipping weekend or a free taster with gift orders). Your unfair advantage on Black Friday isn’t price — it’s being the only coffee gift that’s personal.

How “Gift the Quiz” works

- **Digital:** giver buys a match (single, trio, or 3-month subscription tier) → recipient gets a beautiful email or printable card → takes the quiz → coffee arrives matched, with their archetype card in the box.
- **Physical:** a boxed version — an elegant card with a code inside the signature box — for people who need something to put under a tree.
- Every gift recipient is a new customer acquired at zero ad cost who starts with the full brand experience. This is the growth loop: customer → gift → new customer → gift...

09 Measurement: What to Watch & What Good Looks Like

One 30-minute ritual, every Monday, same five numbers. Everything else is noise. Targets below assume the plan's ad budgets; judge July–August on trend, not size.

Metric	Plain-language meaning	Target by Oct 1	Target by Dec 31
Email list (quiz-qualified)	People who finished the quiz and gave an email	1,200–2,000	4,000–6,000
Quiz completion rate	Of people who start the quiz, how many finish	60%+	65%+
Cost per subscriber	Ad spend ÷ new quiz-qualified emails	\$2–4	\$2–4
Launch conversion	% of the list that buys in launch week	6–10%	—
Cost per first order (CAC)	Total marketing spend ÷ new customers	—	under ~\$35–45, trending down

The one relationship that decides everything: CAC vs. LTV. If it costs \$35 to win a customer (CAC) who goes on to spend \$150+ over a year (LTV — much easier with subscriptions), the machine works and you can spend confidently. If LTV doesn't clear roughly 3× CAC, fix retention before raising ad budgets. This single ratio is what “marketing is working” means in numbers.

Deliberately ignored: follower counts, likes, impressions. Track them casually for morale; never make decisions on them.

Budget allocation guidance

Whatever the total, the split matters more than the amount. A sensible starting allocation for Jul–Dec:

Share	Where	Notes
~40%	Paid distribution (Meta ads)	≈\$3–5k pre-launch at plan budgets, scaling after launch only if CAC math works.
~25%	Content & production	Shoots, props, printing, any freelance editing — protect this; it's the moat.
~15%	PR boxes, influencer seeding, gifts	20–30 boxes in September, second wave for holiday.
~10%	Tools	Mailchimp tier, analytics, link tools, review platform.
~10%	Held back	Opportunity/contingency — something will surprise you in Q4.

10 Risks & Honest Notes

- **The research is directional, not proof.** 35 warm-network respondents validated the idea and the tone. The first real test is quiz completion and launch conversion. Hold the strategy loosely until October data confirms it.
- **Two people is the real constraint, not budget.** This plan is deliberately sequenced so no week requires more than the two of you plus the design team. If something slips, cut paid spend before cutting content quality — the moat is the content.
- **Stated pain ≠ willingness to pay.** People said they hate guessing; whether they'll pay for curation is the launch-week question. The trial size and Right Match Promise exist to lower that bar.
- **Inventory across six archetypes is a forecasting puzzle.** Use quiz data (which archetypes dominate your list) to weight inventory before October — this is a quiet superpower most brands don't have.
- **Don't let the holiday season stretch you into discounting.** The brand's pricing integrity in its first 90 days sets expectations for years.

11 The Next 14 Days

Everything starts here. In order:

- 1. Change September 1 → October 1 on the site (10 minutes, do it today).
- 2. Dana: gate quiz results behind email; pass archetype + Bloom Dial setting to Mailchimp as tags.
- 3. Dana: install GA4 and the Meta Pixel on the site.
- 4. Camila: write Email #1 ("You're [Archetype]. Here's why.") — I can draft all five with you.
- 5. Together: pricing workshop using Section 05 — bag, trial, subscription, promise wording.
- 6. Camila: plan the first archetype shoot; set the 3–4×/week Instagram rhythm.
- 7. Book the September PR-box list (start collecting 20–30 names/addresses now).

12 Glossary — Marketing Words, In Plain Language

Term	What it actually means
Funnel	The path from stranger → aware → interested → customer. “Top of funnel” = strangers; “bottom” = ready to buy.
Lead magnet	Something valuable given free in exchange for an email. Your quiz result is the lead magnet.
Conversion rate	Of the people who could take an action, the % who did (finished the quiz, bought, clicked).
CAC (customer acquisition cost)	Total marketing spend ÷ number of new customers. What one customer costs to win.
LTV (lifetime value)	Everything a customer spends with you over their whole relationship. Subscriptions make this big.
AOV (average order value)	Average \$ per order. Free-shipping thresholds and bundles push it up.
Open rate / click rate	% of email recipients who opened / who clicked something inside.
Retargeting	Ads shown specifically to people who already visited your site but didn't act.
Segmentation	Splitting your list into groups (e.g., by archetype) so each gets more relevant messages.
BFCM	Black Friday + Cyber Monday — the Nov 27–30 peak of US online shopping.
Risk reversal	Removing the customer's risk instead of cutting price (guarantees, free trials, the Right Match Promise).
UGC (user-generated content)	Photos/videos customers make — unboxings, first sips. The most trusted ad format that exists.
Seeding	Sending free product to press/creators hoping they share it. No guarantee — hence “seeding.”
Churn / retention	Churn = subscribers who cancel; retention = those who stay. The numbers that decide LTV.

Prepared for Camila & Dana · July 2026 · A living document — revisit with real quiz data in September, and after launch week.